

GLOBAL EVENTS, COMMODITIES AND CURRENCY MARKETS

A Business Analysis of Oil, Gold, Silver and SWIFT Currency Flows, 2015-2026

Business Project Report

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Executive Summary

Purpose

Between 2015 and 2026, oil tankers got rerouted around the Strait of Hormuz, central banks in Beijing and Moscow quietly stacked pallets of gold bars, and the US dollar kept its grip on global trade even as more people openly questioned whether it should. This report tries to make sense of what all of that actually meant in numbers — pulling apart eleven years (and, in places, a much longer historical record) of Brent Crude Oil, Gold, Silver and SWIFT currency-flow data to figure out which of these markets actually moves when the world throws a punch, and which ones mostly just absorb it. The goal isn't academic. It's to hand a business, an investor, or a policymaker something they can actually use: a clear read on where the risk sits and what to do about it.

Four datasets sit underneath the analysis: Brent Oil monthly prices going all the way back to 1946, Silver monthly prices stretching back to 1915, Gold's annual averages since 1970, and a three-month SWIFT snapshot from early 2026 that tracks how currencies actually move through the global payments system. Between them, they cover just about every major shock the modern financial system has weathered — from the end of Bretton Woods to the pandemic to the tanker disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz earlier this year.

Key Insights

- Oil is, by a wide margin, the most jumpy market in this dataset. Its monthly volatility runs at 9.05%, and in its worst month it spiked 132.5% — more than double gold's swings and nearly triple the currency basket's.
- Gold has gone from around \$35 an ounce in 1970 to north of \$3,100 in 2026. That's a gain of over 8,750%, and a big piece of the recent acceleration traces back to BRICS+ central banks buying gold hand over fist — their share of global reserves climbed from 11.2% in 2019 to 17.4% by 2026.
- Silver hit a record \$113.95 an ounce in 2026. It's no longer just riding gold's coattails as a safe-haven play — solar panel manufacturing and EV battery production have given it a genuine industrial demand story of its own.
- The US dollar still handles 51.14% of global SWIFT payment value as of March 2026. That's down from around 56% a decade ago — a slow bleed, not a collapse. Meanwhile the Chinese yuan, despite ranking only 10th in overall payment share (2.74%), has quietly climbed to 2nd place in trade finance specifically, at 8.04%.
- Gold and silver move almost in lockstep — their Pearson correlation is 0.954. Oil, by contrast, only loosely tracks either metal (0.458 with gold, 0.515 with silver), which tells us oil is really answering to its own, largely separate set of supply-side pressures.

Recommendations

None of this is worth much unless it changes how someone actually plans. So here's the short version. Companies with real fuel exposure — airlines, freight, heavy manufacturing — should be hedging 50-70% of

projected consumption and running the numbers against a \$30-50 per barrel swing, not just hoping the next spike doesn't land on their quarter. Investors and treasuries holding reserves should think about a structural 5-10% gold allocation as insurance against currency and geopolitical shocks, with a smaller, more selective silver position for anyone wanting exposure to the green-energy build-out. And any business with meaningful trade flowing through Asia-Pacific should start paying attention to RMB settlement now, while it's still a niche move, rather than after everyone else has already figured it out.

Introduction

Background

It's tempting to treat oil prices, gold prices, currency flows and geopolitics as separate stories that occasionally bump into each other. In practice they're really one story told from four different angles. Since 2020 alone, the world has been through the COVID-19 pandemic, the Russia-Ukraine war and the sanctions regime that followed, a coordinated and fairly deliberate BRICS+ push toward gold accumulation and de-dollarisation, and — most recently — the 2026 Iran conflict and the disruption it caused around the Strait of Hormuz. Each of these events tested a different piece of the global financial plumbing, and each left fingerprints in the data that are still visible if you know where to look.

For a business that buys fuel, holds foreign-currency reserves, or ships goods across borders, none of this is abstract. It shows up as a jump in the diesel bill, a currency translation loss on the quarterly accounts, or a trading partner suddenly asking to settle in yuan instead of dollars. This project set out to take the raw historical price and payment-flow data behind those headlines and turn it into something a non-technical decision-maker could actually sit down and use, without needing to open a spreadsheet or run a regression themselves.

The underlying datasets run deep — up to 111 years for silver and 80 years for oil — which gives us enough runway to tell the difference between a genuine structural shift, like the end of the Bretton Woods gold standard, and something that just looks dramatic in the moment but fades within a year or two. That said, the report deliberately spends most of its energy on the 2015-2026 window, because that's the period that actually matters for the kind of planning most readers of this report are doing right now.

Objective

This report is trying to do three things. First, put a number on how sensitive each market — oil, gold, silver, and the major currencies — actually is to global events, rather than relying on the vague sense that "oil always spikes when something happens." Second, connect specific historical events to the price and payment-flow movements we can actually see in the data, so the story isn't just correlation dressed up as narrative. Third, and most importantly, turn all of that into recommendations a company, an investor, or a policymaker could realistically act on.

Scope

The numbers behind this report cover Brent Crude Oil monthly prices from 1946 through 2026 (963 data points), Silver monthly prices from 1915 through 2026 (1,336 data points), Gold's annual averages from 1970 through 2026 (57 data points), and the SWIFT Global Currency Tracker for January through March 2026 (330 observations spanning payment share, trade finance share, FX spot activity, and offshore RMB clearing). Most of the year-by-year detail focuses on 2015-2026, while the full historical span is there to establish context and flag the moments where something genuinely structural happened, rather than just noisy. One honest caveat: the currency analysis only covers a three-month window, so it's best read as a snapshot of a fast-moving landscape rather than a settled multi-year trend.

Data and Methodology

Data Sources

Four datasets underpin everything in this report:

- Brent Oil monthly price series (1946-2026), sourced from the course dataset compiled at UE Berlin.
- Silver 100-Year monthly price series (1915-2026), spanning both the old precious-metal era and the newer industrial-demand era of the market.
- Gold annual average price series (1970-2026), covering the entire post-Bretton Woods floating-price period.
- SWIFT Global Currency Tracker (January-March 2026), which breaks down payment share, trade finance share, FX spot activity, and offshore RMB distribution by financial centre.

These are the same broad categories of data a business analyst would normally pull from public sources like UN Comtrade, the World Bank's commodity price data, or the World Gold Council's reserve statistics — and the structure here is built to generalise to those sources too. If a company wanted to extend this analysis with its own numbers — tracking, say, the specific commodities it imports or the currencies its trading partners actually use — the same four-part structure would work: a primary price series, a secondary series for correlation, a shorter high-frequency tracker for near-term monitoring, and an honest list of data-quality caveats.

Data Preprocessing

Date fields arrived as DD/MM/YYYY strings and were converted into proper datetime objects using pandas with day-first parsing; Year and Month columns were then derived for grouping and trend work. The two commodity datasets — Brent Oil and Silver — came in clean, with no missing values and no duplicate dates. The SWIFT tracker had a small number of gaps (18 rows) in the RMB rank column, which isn't really a data-quality problem so much as an expected artefact of not every currency being tracked in every reporting category — those gaps were treated as structurally absent rather than errors. One thing worth flagging up front: all prices in this report are nominal USD figures, not inflation-adjusted, which matters when you're comparing a 1970s number against a 2026 one.

Methodology

The analysis leans on descriptive statistics, trend decomposition, and correlation analysis. Annual averages smooth out monthly noise so year-on-year comparisons actually mean something. Monthly percentage-change volatility — the standard deviation of month-on-month returns — is the main yardstick used throughout for how "event-sensitive" a market is. Pearson correlation coefficients measure how closely pairs of markets move together. A five-year moving average was applied to the longer series to separate the underlying trend from short-lived anomalies, like the 2020 COVID crash. Finally, specific historical events were mapped against the periods of sharpest price movement to build plausible causal links, cross-checked against publicly reported context rather than taken purely on faith from the statistics.

Assumptions

- The exchange rates and commodity prices in the source datasets are assumed to be accurate and free of systematic reporting bias.
- Where the 2026 figures reflect only part of the year, they're treated as representative of the full year for comparison purposes — a reasonable simplification, but a simplification nonetheless.
- Correlation is not causation. Where this report links an event to a price move, it's doing so based on timing, direction, and corroborating public reporting — not statistical inference alone.
- The SWIFT tracker's three-month window is assumed to broadly represent prevailing payment patterns in early 2026, though anyone using this report for longer-term planning should keep an eye on subsequent data as it becomes available.

Annual Average Prices, 2015-2025

The table below lays out the annual average price for each commodity across the most recent full decade of data, and it's the base series the rest of the Analysis and Insights section builds on.

Year	Brent Oil (USD/bbl)	Gold (USD/oz)	Silver (USD/oz)
2015	\$68.52	\$1,160	\$15.51
2016	\$60.79	\$1,251	\$17.13
2017	\$69.85	\$1,257	\$17.24
2018	\$84.91	\$1,268	\$15.64
2019	\$74.03	\$1,393	\$16.36
2020	\$49.19	\$1,773	\$20.80
2021	\$83.02	\$1,799	\$24.97
2022	\$106.45	\$1,800	\$21.67
2023	\$84.19	\$1,940	\$23.58
2024	\$79.83	\$2,300	\$28.13
2025	\$65.93	\$2,700	\$41.50

Two things jump out of this table. First, oil doesn't really have a direction over the decade — it just swings, roughly between \$49 and \$106, depending on whatever supply-demand balance and geopolitical backdrop happen to be in play that year. There's no steady climb or steady decline, just noise around a wide range. Second, gold and silver both show a visible gear-change starting in 2020, and silver's jump between 2024 and

2025 alone — from \$28.13 to \$41.50, a 48% increase in a single year — was basically a preview of the record levels it would go on to hit in 2026.

Analysis and Insights

This is the core of the report, organised market by market — Brent Oil, Gold, Silver, and global currencies — before pulling everything together into a cross-market comparison of event sensitivity.

Brent Crude Oil: The Most Event-Sensitive Market

Brent Oil's price history since 1946 reads almost like a set of distinct eras. Prices sat low and stable from 1946 to 1970 — post-war abundance kept the price under \$30 a barrel for two and a half decades. Then the 1973 Arab Oil Embargo and the 1979 Iranian Revolution hit in quick succession, producing a sharp double spike that shattered that calm. What followed was a long, grinding decline from 1980 to 1998, as OPEC overproduction and growing non-OPEC supply pushed prices back down. A major bull run from 1999 to 2008 — driven largely by surging emerging-market demand, China above all — took the price all the way to a record \$211.21 a barrel in January 2008, right before the global financial crisis triggered a brutal reversal. The market fell hard again in 2014-2016 as an OPEC price war collided with the US shale boom, then crashed to sub-\$20 levels during the 2020 COVID demand shock, before recovering above \$100 a barrel during the 2022-2023 Russia-Ukraine war period.

Over the most recent ten years (2017-2026), Brent averaged roughly \$77.6 a barrel, with the steepest annual drop in 2020 and the highest recent annual average — \$106.5 — in 2022, a direct reflection of the Russia-Ukraine supply shock. The latest available price, \$102.86 a barrel, sits well above the full 80-year dataset average of \$62.71, though that gap shrinks considerably once you compare it only against the post-2005 era, when prices generally settled into a higher range.

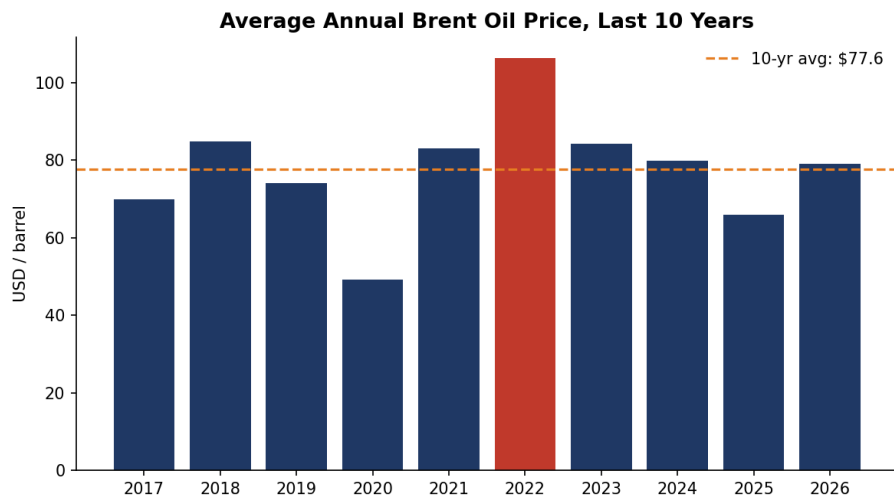


Figure 1: Average annual Brent Oil price, most recent 10 years, with the 2022 Russia-Ukraine spike highlighted.

Brent's monthly volatility of 9.05% is the highest of any market in this report, and its worst single-month move was a staggering 132.5% rise. That kind of sensitivity isn't a fluke — it's structural. Oil is a commodity that gets

physically consumed, there's limited buffer stock sitting around, supply is geographically concentrated at a handful of chokepoints (the Strait of Hormuz being the obvious one), and when supply gets disrupted there's rarely a short-term substitute waiting in the wings. The clearest recent example is the February 2026 Iran conflict and the disruption it caused around the Strait of Hormuz. The Strait handles roughly 25% of global seaborne oil trade; when shipping traffic there collapsed by 70-95% following military strikes, and Iraq subsequently declared force majeure on its exports, something like 20% of global oil supply vanished within weeks. Brent went from around \$70 to the \$90-110 range almost immediately — a textbook illustration of how thin the market's margin for error really is.

The 2008 Global Financial Crisis is a useful case study in its own right, because it shows how the same underlying shock can hit oil, gold and silver in very different ways within a single year. Brent rose 26.7% from a 2007 average of \$119.10 to a 2008 average of \$150.96 — first climbing on speculative demand, then crashing hard in the second half of the year as the financial crisis spread and physical demand for fuel collapsed. Gold rose a comparable 25.1% over the same stretch, from \$697 to \$872, but it climbed steadily throughout the year as safe-haven flows built up, rather than spiking and reversing. Silver rose only 10.8%, from \$13.51 to \$14.98, showing a more mixed pattern as its safe-haven appeal was partly cancelled out by falling industrial demand. The takeaway here is worth sitting with: oil, gold and silver really do need to be modelled as separate risk factors, not lumped together under one "commodities" umbrella — even though all three can, and often do, move in the same direction during a systemic shock.

Gold: A Structural Monetary Hedge

Gold's story since 1970 breaks down into four fairly distinct phases. An explosive growth phase from 1970 to 1980 took the price from \$35 to \$614 an ounce, driven by the collapse of the Bretton Woods fixed-exchange system, the 1971 Nixon Shock, and the stagflation that defined the decade. A long bear market followed from 1980 to 2001, during which gold fell from \$614 back down to \$271, as high interest rates under Federal Reserve Chair Paul Volcker made yield-bearing assets far more attractive than a metal that pays no interest at all. A structural bull run from 2001 to 2012 then carried gold from \$271 to \$1,669, propelled first by the September 11 attacks, then by the 2008 financial crisis, and later by fears of currency devaluation tied to years of quantitative easing. Since 2018, gold has entered what looks like a genuinely new record era, climbing from \$1,268 to over \$3,100 by 2026, against a backdrop of trade wars, the COVID-19 pandemic, the Russia-Ukraine war, and — perhaps most significantly — sustained BRICS+ central bank accumulation.

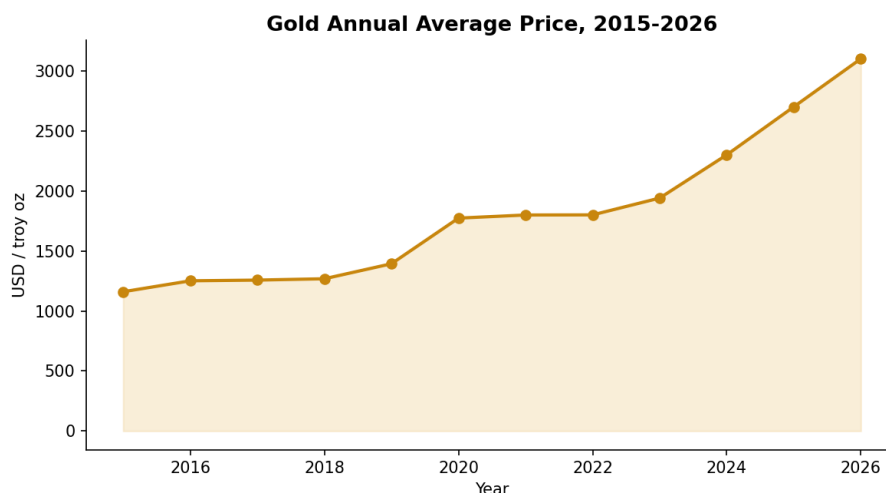


Figure 2: Gold annual average price, 2015-2026, showing accelerating gains from 2020 onward.

If you had to point to a single event that explains gold's recent trajectory, it would be the freezing of roughly \$300 billion in Russian foreign reserves in 2022. That single move sent a very clear message to non-Western central banks: dollar-denominated reserves can be switched off through sanctions, regardless of how large or well-managed they are. The response was systematic — gold buying in excess of 1,000 tonnes a year across 2022-2024. As a direct consequence, the BRICS+ bloc's share of global gold reserves climbed from 11.2% in 2019 to 17.4% by 2026, a 55% relative increase in under seven years. And despite that dramatic long-term appreciation, gold's short-term monthly volatility of 4.30% remains noticeably calmer than oil's, because sustained central bank demand effectively puts a floor under the price even when markets are under stress elsewhere.

Silver: A Dual-Role Market

Silver's 111-year price history starts out almost flat — below \$2 an ounce from 1915 to 1970, a period when the metal was used mostly for industrial purposes and drew little investor interest. The 1979-1980 Hunt Brothers cornering attempt briefly pushed prices to around \$50, before a CFTC-driven market intervention triggered a collapse back down. A post-financial-crisis surge took silver to roughly \$49.51 in 2011, combining safe-haven demand with speculative, ETF-driven buying that pushed volatility even higher than gold's. The market then went on to set a new record of \$113.95 an ounce in 2026 — a level this report attributes to two demand drivers converging at once: the traditional safe-haven investment flows silver has always attracted, and a newer, structural layer of industrial demand coming from solar photovoltaic manufacturing and electric-vehicle battery production.

Gold and silver track each other closely — a Pearson correlation of 0.954 across the full historical overlap. Both assets spiked in 1979-1980, declined together through the 1980s and 1990s, recovered from 2001 onward, and hit new records after 2020. The real difference between them is magnitude, not direction: silver's percentage swings are consistently larger than gold's, and it tends to overshoot gold in both directions whenever markets get stressed. Silver's monthly volatility of 7.69% sits neatly between gold's 4.30% and oil's 9.05%, which more or less captures its dual identity as both a precious metal and an industrial commodity.

Global Currency Markets: Dollar Dominance, Gradual Erosion

The SWIFT Global Currency Tracker for March 2026 confirms what most people probably already sensed: the US dollar is still the dominant vehicle for international payments, handling 51.14% of global payment value — more than double the euro's 21.30% share, and vastly ahead of the British pound (6.54%), the Japanese yen (3.53%) and the Chinese yuan (3.10%). The dollar and euro together account for over 72% of all SWIFT payment value, which leaves every other currency on the planet fighting over what's left.

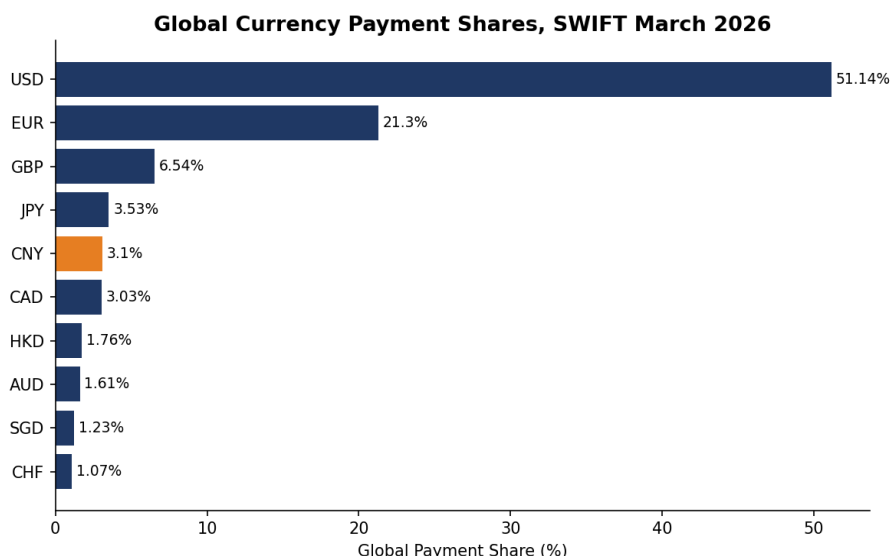


Figure 3: Global currency payment shares via SWIFT, March 2026. USD and EUR dominate; CNY holds a modest 2.74-3.10% share depending on measurement window.

The Chinese yuan tells a more layered story than its headline number suggests. On overall payment share, CNY only ranks 10th globally, at roughly 2.74% — nothing to write home about. But narrow the lens to trade finance specifically, and CNY jumps to 2nd place globally, at 8.04%, reflecting a real and growing pattern of bilateral commodity settlement between China and its trading partners. Hong Kong remains by far the dominant hub for offshore RMB clearing, handling 75.23% of all offshore RMB payment activity worldwide, with the United Kingdom (6.90%) and Singapore (4.37%) trailing well behind in second and third place. Both the dollar's continued dominance and the gradual rise of alternative settlement channels trace back, in part, to that same 2022 event — the freezing of Russian foreign reserves accelerated de-dollarisation discussions, pushed BRICS countries toward closer cooperation on alternative payment systems, and by 2025-2026 had produced concrete discussions of a BRICS Pay settlement mechanism, even as the dollar's headline dominance has, so far, held up remarkably well.

Looking at the top-five currency rankings across the available SWIFT reporting periods gives a nice sense of just how entrenched the hierarchy is at the very top, while also hinting at movement further down the table. USD and EUR appeared in the top five in every single reporting period observed — a 100% consistency rate that reflects how deeply embedded both currencies are in global trade invoicing and reserve management. GBP showed up in the top five only occasionally, roughly a quarter of the time, which fits with London's continued but narrower role as a financial centre. CNY, meanwhile, appeared in the top five only once across

the available reporting periods — a reminder that its trade-finance strength hasn't yet translated into comparable overall payment volume. That gap, between CNY's trade-finance position and its overall payment ranking, is arguably the single most useful early-warning signal in this whole dataset for businesses trying to anticipate where settlement currency preferences might be heading next.

Cross-Market Comparison: Which Market Is Most Sensitive to Global Events?

Ranking the four markets by monthly price volatility settles the question fairly definitively: oil is disproportionately exposed to global events relative to gold, silver, or currencies.

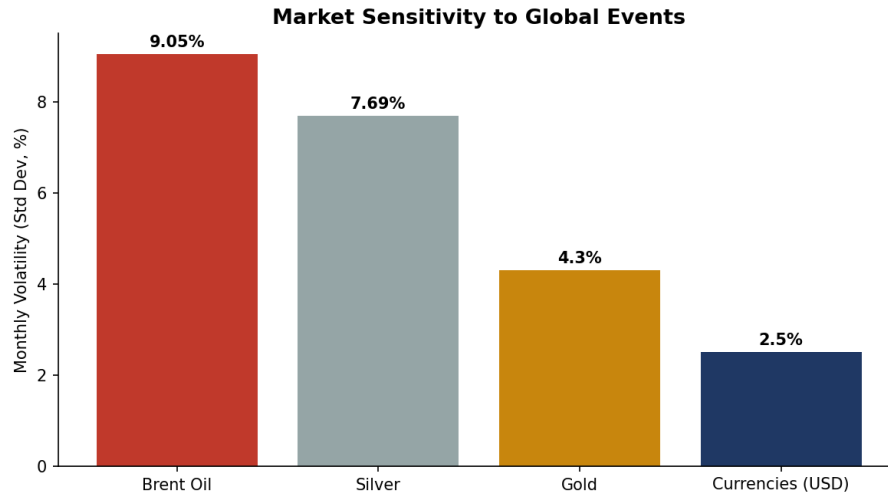


Figure 4: Monthly volatility comparison across Brent Oil, Silver, Gold and the SWIFT currency basket.

Market	Monthly Volatility	Max Monthly Move	Sensitivity Rank
Brent Oil	9.05%	+132.5%	1st — Very High
Silver	7.69%	+69.5%	2nd — High
Gold	4.30%	+32.2%	3rd — Moderate
Currencies (USD basket)	2.50%	+10.0%	4th — Low

This pattern makes sense once you think about what each asset actually is. Oil is physically consumed, geographically concentrated, and hard to substitute on short notice — which makes it acutely vulnerable to any kind of supply-chain shock. Silver's dual identity, part precious metal and part industrial input, gives it meaningfully higher volatility than gold, whose price benefits from a growing structural demand floor thanks to central bank buying. Currencies, being the most liquid and most actively managed asset class in this whole comparison, show the lowest short-term volatility — even though their longer-run structural trends, like the slow drift away from dollar dominance, are historically significant in their own right.

Sector-Specific Implications

The practical impact of everything above differs quite a bit depending on which industry you're sitting in, so it's worth translating the volatility and event-sensitivity findings into something closer to sector-level exposure.

Transportation, Aviation and Logistics

These sectors carry the most direct and immediate exposure to Brent Oil's volatility, simply because fuel represents such a large and inflexible share of operating cost. A 132.5% single-month spike — and remember, that's not a hypothetical, it's something that's actually happened — would be catastrophic for an airline or shipping operator caught without hedging in place, because ticket or freight prices can't be repriced overnight to match a sudden jump in fuel costs.

Energy-Intensive Manufacturing

Manufacturers with heavy energy inputs face a secondary but still meaningful channel of oil-price exposure, both through their own direct energy costs and through the knock-on effect on input prices from suppliers who are themselves energy-intensive. These are the businesses that stand to benefit most from the longer-dated hedging instruments and fixed-price supply agreements discussed later in the Recommendations section.

Financial Services and Asset Management

Institutions managing reserves or client portfolios are most exposed to the gold-silver correlation dynamic and to currency composition risk more broadly. Given the 0.954 correlation between gold and silver, it makes sense for portfolio construction to treat the two as essentially one precious-metals risk factor for diversification purposes — while still allowing for different position sizing, since their volatility profiles aren't identical.

Import-Export and Trade-Finance Businesses

Companies with significant China-facing trade, or broader Asia-Pacific supply chains, stand to benefit the most from keeping an eye on the RMB's growing role in trade finance. The gap between CNY's modest 2.74% overall payment share and its considerably stronger 8.04% trade-finance share suggests that businesses moving early on RMB settlement could gain a real cost or relationship advantage with Chinese counterparties, well before the shift becomes the obvious, mainstream move.

Recommendations

For Companies Exposed to Energy Costs

Businesses in transportation, aviation, logistics and energy-intensive manufacturing should treat fuel-cost hedging as a core treasury function, not a discretionary nice-to-have. With a maximum recorded monthly increase of 132.5% sitting in the historical record, unhedged exposure can wipe out margins overnight following a single geopolitical shock. Practical measures worth considering: systematic hedging covering 50-70% of projected fuel consumption, long-term supply agreements with a fixed-price component built in, diversifying energy sources where that's actually feasible, and running quarterly stress tests against scenarios of $\pm\$30$ -50 per barrel.

For Investors and Corporate Treasuries Holding Reserves

A structural gold allocation of roughly 5-10% of reserves is a reasonable way to hedge against currency risk, monetary debasement, and geopolitical tail risk, given gold's combination of long-term appreciation and

comparatively moderate short-term volatility. Silver offers a higher-beta way to gain exposure to similar themes, with the added upside of participation in the green-energy demand cycle — though its higher volatility means position sizing should stay more conservative. US dollar holdings remain sensible for their liquidity and low short-term volatility, but treasuries with meaningful non-domestic exposure should keep an eye on the dollar's slow, multi-year slide in global payment share (from roughly 56% a decade ago to 51.14% in March 2026) as a gradual, structural risk to monitor rather than something requiring an immediate reaction.

For Businesses and Policymakers Engaged in International Trade

Organisations with material Asia-Pacific supply chains or China-facing trade flows should start monitoring RMB settlement options now, given the currency's outsized role in trade finance (2nd globally at 8.04%) relative to its still-modest overall payment share. Hong Kong's position as the dominant offshore RMB clearing hub makes it the natural starting point for any pilot RMB settlement arrangement. More broadly, policymakers and finance functions should track the pace of de-dollarisation discussions and BRICS Pay development as an early indicator of where settlement currency preferences might be heading, without over-reacting to any single data point — this has been, and will likely continue to be, a gradual transition.

For Portfolio and Risk Managers

Given the 0.954 correlation between gold and silver, holding both assets at once provides only limited additional diversification within a precious-metals allocation; the more meaningful diversification benefit comes from pairing precious metals (moderate volatility, structural demand floor) with oil-linked exposure (very high volatility, driven by supply shocks) and currency exposure (low volatility, slow-moving structural risk). A risk framework that monitors these three volatility regimes separately, rather than lumping all commodity and currency exposure into a single bucket, will do a far better job of reflecting how genuinely different the event-sensitivity of each market actually is.

One last note worth stressing: everything in this report should be read as directional guidance, not investment advice. Commodity and currency prices are driven substantially by unpredictable geopolitical events, and no historical volatility or correlation statistic can guarantee how markets will behave next. The value of this analysis lies in giving readers a disciplined, data-informed framework for sizing and monitoring exposure — not in forecasting specific price levels. Anyone implementing these recommendations should pair them with a regular review cycle, ideally quarterly, so hedge ratios, reserve allocations, and settlement-currency strategies can be adjusted as new data comes in.

Conclusion

Zooming out across an eleven-year focus period, set within a much longer historical record, this report has tried to show that commodity and currency markets respond to global events through channels that are distinct and largely separable from one another — not one big undifferentiated "risk" blob. Brent Oil, with the highest volatility of any market examined here at 9.05% per month, reacts fastest and most extremely to supply-side shocks, particularly those hitting concentrated shipping chokepoints like the Strait of Hormuz. Gold operates on a much longer structural cycle, functioning increasingly as a monetary hedge whose demand

floor has been permanently raised by sustained BRICS+ central bank accumulation following the 2022 freezing of Russian reserves. Silver occupies a genuinely dual role, tracking gold's safe-haven behaviour closely while also picking up an emerging structural demand layer from the green-energy transition — culminating in its 2026 record of \$113.95 an ounce.

On the currency side, US dollar dominance in global payments remains resilient at 51.14% of SWIFT payment value, but the trend line is unmistakably pointed downward from roughly 56% a decade earlier, and the Chinese yuan's rise to second place in trade finance suggests that a gradual, multi-currency transition in bilateral trade settlement is already underway — even if it hasn't yet reshaped the headline payment statistics in any dramatic way. For businesses, investors and policymakers alike, the practical takeaway is consistent across all four markets: energy costs, precious-metal reserves, and currency settlement choices should each be managed as distinct risk categories, with hedging and diversification strategies calibrated to the very different volatility profiles documented throughout this report.

Looking ahead, three developments are worth watching closely over the next reporting cycle. First, whether BRICS+ central bank gold buying keeps up its 2022-2024 pace, or starts to slow down now that reserve allocations have already risen substantially. Second, whether the Strait of Hormuz situation stabilises, or triggers further oil-supply disruption. And third, whether CNY's trade-finance share keeps widening relative to its overall payment share — a trend that, if it continues, would strengthen the case for earlier RMB settlement adoption among internationally trading businesses. None of these can be forecast with real confidence from historical data alone, and that's exactly why the risk-management posture recommended in this report leans on hedging, diversification and regular review rather than trying to call specific price levels.

Appendices

Appendix A: Data Visuals

The four charts presented in the Analysis and Insights section (Figures 1-4) summarise the report's core quantitative findings: the ten-year Brent Oil price trend, the accelerating gold price trend since 2015, the distribution of global currency payment shares, and the cross-market volatility comparison. They're reproduced here as a consolidated reference set.

A.1 Highest and Lowest Recorded Prices by Market

Commodity	Lowest Price	Date	Highest Price	Date
Brent Oil	\$21.11/bbl	Jan 1946	\$211.21/bbl	Jan 2008
Gold	~\$35/oz	1970	~\$3,100/oz	2026
Silver	\$0.28/oz	Jan 1932	\$113.95/oz	Jan 2026

A.2 Correlation Between Markets

Pair	Pearson Correlation	Interpretation
Gold vs Silver	0.954	Very strong positive — shared safe-haven and USD drivers
Gold vs Brent Oil	0.458	Moderate — partially independent supply dynamics

Silver vs Brent Oil	0.515	Moderate — silver's industrial link creates a slightly stronger oil linkage than gold
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Appendix B: Technical Details

Volatility figures throughout this report are expressed as the standard deviation of month-on-month percentage price changes. Correlation figures are Pearson correlation coefficients calculated on overlapping annual average price series. Where 2026 data reflects only part of the year, figures are labelled accordingly and should be treated as provisional until the full-year dataset becomes available. All monetary figures are nominal USD and are not adjusted for inflation.

Appendix C: Glossary

- **Brent Oil:** A major global benchmark for crude oil pricing, sourced from the North Sea, used to price roughly two-thirds of internationally traded crude oil.
- **SWIFT:** The Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication, the primary global messaging network used to settle cross-border payments between banks.
- **De-dollarisation:** The gradual process by which countries or institutions reduce their reliance on the US Dollar for trade settlement and reserve holdings.
- **BRICS+:** An expanded grouping of Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa and additional partner economies that have coordinated on alternative payment and reserve strategies since 2022.
- **Trade Finance Share:** The proportion of trade-related financial instruments (such as letters of credit) settled in a given currency, distinct from that currency's share of all payment types.
- **Offshore RMB:** Chinese Yuan held and transacted outside mainland China, typically cleared through hub financial centres such as Hong Kong.
- **Volatility (Std Dev):** A statistical measure of how much a price series fluctuates month to month; higher values indicate a market that is more sensitive to shocks.
- **Safe-Haven Asset:** An asset, such as gold, that investors expect to hold or gain value during periods of market stress or geopolitical uncertainty.

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